

Murder Mystery

Dinner Party 2026



Reed DeLabel

The Meridian Museum

October 30, 2026 / Private player packet / 1 of 12

INTRODUCTIONS



Reed DeLabel

Doctoral Fellow in Art History

Reed reads every label aloud, including the exit sign. Reed is the youngest scholar attached to the exhibition and has been trying very hard to behave like this is normal.

- **Dr. Art E. Fact** supervises Reed's doctorate and rarely returns a clean draft.
- Gets informal guidance from **Claire O'Scuro** on exhibition labels and curatorial work.
- Checks dates and catalog references for **Paige Turner**. Reed saves any article that includes a correction.
- **Anne E. Dote** coaches Reed through gallery tours. She keeps crossing footnotes out of the children's handouts.

ACTING TIPS

Eager, cerebral, anxious in a useful way, unexpectedly bold when the evidence is on your side.

YOUR INTRODUCTION / READ THE BOX ALOUD

I'm Reed DeLabel. I am the graduate fellow. I know where the footnotes go and, more dangerously, where they are missing.

Continue to your private briefing on page 3. Keep the packet facing you.



Behind the portrait

Your grievance with Grant

You found an archival document that contradicted the Star Bowl label. Grant told your department your fellowship could disappear if you pushed it.

Your other secret

You have not yet told Art that your discovery also undermines one sentence in his published research.

Conversations to start

- Ask Claire O'Scuro whether she is comfortable with the Star Bowl label.
- Ask Dr. Art E. Fact how a junior researcher should challenge a donor's version of history.

One attending guest committed the murder alone. Follow your printed account during the hearings. If a named guest is absent, speak to someone else.

By now, you should have drawn a secret animal. Memorize it and don't share it with anyone. This animal is YOUR key to knowing whether you are the murderer or innocent tonight. This will tell you which sections of this packet you can read out loud.



**STOP! Do not turn the page yet.
Wait for the host to announce the next round.**



The game is afoot

The Meridian Museum has its share of secrets, rumors, and lost paperwork. Sixteen numbered envelopes are hidden around the museum. Their contents may significantly help you tonight. These 3 hints lead to 3 different hiding places. If you find an envelope, bring it to your seat at the table. The guest with the most envelopes will win a special prize. You may investigate together.

- 1 *Four legs and a metallic seat guard a secret from below.*
- 2 *Behind a cupboard's closed doors, one item has no domestic purpose.*
- 3 *Seek the sacred book with two testaments. Tonight its pages shelter evidence.*



STOP! Do not turn the page yet.
Wait for the host to announce the next round.



Questions for the room

Choose a named guest who has not answered. Skip absent names. Ask their question; they answer from page 6, then choose the next guest.

Artie Ficial / Monet Bags / Tess Tament

What did Grant demand from you, and what had you already concealed?

Claire O'Scuro / Chip Patina / Sue Venir

What did Grant pressure you to approve or overlook?

Hugh Bidder / Elon Mosaic / Saul D. Bid

What hidden transaction made Grant a threat to you?

Dada DiCapo / Vincent Van Faux / Drew Conclusions

How did Grant threaten your work or reputation?

Dr. Art E. Fact / Reed DeLabel / Justin Tyme

What truth did Grant want suppressed, and what could embarrass you?

Barb Dwyer / Paige Turner / Faye Stop

What did Grant ask you to hide?

Frank Lloyd Wrong / Al Baster / Minnie Malist

What compromise in your work gave Grant leverage over you?

Mona Lott / Elle Loominate / Robin Banks

What did you want returned or protected?

Anya Tique / Ella Gance / Penny Pincher

What past agreement was about to become a public dispute?

Brie DeVivre / Cary Crates / Anne E. Dote

How did Grant threaten your work, and how did you respond?

Your speaking box is on page 6. Turn only within this act.



Reed DeLabel

Your answer

Read only the bordered words when asked. Keep your packet facing you.
After answering, ask an unheard guest their question from the previous page.

IF INNOCENT

I copied a reference too quickly and concealed what the original meant for Art's research. Correcting it would embarrass him as well as me. Grant wanted the old attribution restored because it suited the exhibition. I was expected to take responsibility for the careless note and then keep repeating it. I wanted somebody to read the source before deciding what my work was worth.

IF MURDERER

I copied a reference too quickly and concealed what the original meant for Art's research. Correcting it would embarrass him as well as me. Grant wanted the old attribution restored because it suited the exhibition. I was expected to take responsibility for the careless note and then keep repeating it. He treated my fellowship as a reason I would obey him.



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Reed DeLabel

Questions for the room

Choose a named guest who has not answered. Skip absent names. Ask their question; they answer from page 8, then choose the next guest.

Artie Ficial / Paige Turner / Justin Tyme

What task or errand occupied you before the toast?

Claire O'Scuro / Vincent Van Faux / Saul D. Bid

How did you approach Grant about your papers or work?

Hugh Bidder / Tess Tament / Anya Tique / Ella Gance

When did you first enter, and what business did you have with Grant?

Monet Bags / Brie DeVivre / Robin Banks

Describe your errand at the private service station.

Chip Patina / Al Baster / Cary Crates

What physical work or problem occupied you?

Dada DiCapo / Dr. Art E. Fact / Elon Mosaic

What did Grant want changed, and how did you respond before the toast?

Sue Venir / Elle Loominate / Reed DeLabel

Why did you contact the preparation department, and how did you collect your papers?

Barb Dwyer / Frank Lloyd Wrong / Minnie Malist

What practical museum duty were you handling?

Mona Lott / Drew Conclusions / Penny Pincher

What did you bring Grant, and what happened when you delivered it?

Anne E. Dote / Faye Stop

How did your museum materials bring you through the preparation department?

Your speaking box is on page 8. Turn only within this act.



Reed DeLabel

Your answer

Read only the bordered words when asked. Keep your packet facing you.
After answering, ask an unheard guest their question from the previous page.

IF INNOCENT

I found the reference book shelved under the wrong collection and checked the entry I had copied too quickly. It contradicted the exhibition label and my own working note. I changed the online catalog before asking permission. Grant wanted the old attribution restored before guests looked it up. I kept the source register open on the desk so the archivist could see why I had changed it. My shortcut was no longer a private mistake.

IF MURDERER

I found the reference book shelved under the wrong collection and checked the entry I had copied too quickly. It contradicted the exhibition label and my own working note. I changed the online catalog before asking permission. Grant wanted the old attribution restored before guests looked it up. I kept the source register open on the desk so the archivist could see why I had changed it. My shortcut was no longer a private mistake.



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Reed DeLabel

Questions for the room

Choose a named guest who has not answered. Skip absent names. Ask their question; they answer from page 10, then choose the next guest.

Claire O'Scuro / Sue Venir / Dr. Art E. Fact

What detail on your paperwork or its packaging should we notice?

Artie Ficial / Tess Tament / Minnie Malist

What did you handle around the speech or service preparations?

Hugh Bidder / Elon Mosaic / Saul D. Bid

What original record or material completes your account of the dispute?

Chip Patina / Al Baster / Cary Crates

Which retained record or material explains the work or problem you described?

Dada DiCapo / Vincent Van Faux / Elle Loominate

What physical detail completes your account of the work you wanted protected?

Monet Bags / Anya Tique / Penny Pincher

What was on the material you brought, and what does it actually record?

Barb Dwyer / Brie DeVivre / Robin Banks

What did your access or service arrangements actually involve?

Paige Turner / Drew Conclusions / Faye Stop

Which original or retained material did you handle, and what marks does it bear?

Frank Lloyd Wrong / Reed DeLabel / Anne E. Dote

What does the completed work or return record tell us?

Mona Lott / Ella Gance / Justin Tyme

What retained paper or record supports your account, and what does it disclose?

Your speaking box is on page 10. Turn only within this act.



Reed DeLabel

Your answer

Read only the bordered words when asked. Keep your packet facing you.
After answering, ask an unheard guest their question from the previous page.

IF INNOCENT

The source register identifies the entry I copied without checking. The archivist's reply supplies the correct attribution. I retained both because destroying my notes would not change the object. My shorthand became an exhibition claim it could not support. That is the misconduct the correspondence explains.

IF MURDERER

I copied the unchecked reference into the catalog. Grant wanted me to repeat that attribution over the archivist's objection. I retrieved my notes because I did not want the careless sentence to become my permanent contribution. The inventory records a foil-backed red scrap caught in my reference sleeve. I carried that through the walkthrough and to Grant's table. I moved his glass to put the disputed sentences side by side.



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Reed DeLabel

Your ballot

Choose one attending guest. Explain your accusation in your own words. Detach this page and give only the ballot to the host for tallying. Keep your packet for Coming Clean.

Your character name

I accuse

Why? Motive, evidence and any unresolved contradiction

Best Actor

Best Costume



The last word

Read only when the host calls you. Top three suspects read first. Use your own role's box; keep every other word private.

IF INNOCENT / READ ALOUD WHEN CALLED

I copied an attribution without checking and concealed that the source also undermined Art's research. The register and archivist's reply identify both mistakes. I did not kill Grant. I will correct my catalog entry and tell Art what I found. A junior researcher can admit a shortcut without asking everyone else to keep the wrong attribution.

IF MURDERER / READ ALOUD WHEN CALLED

I took cyanide during the preparation walkthrough. While the glass was uncovered, I used it to poison Grant's glass during that visit. A piece of the bottle seal caught in my reference sleeve when I opened it. I carried it to the table without noticing; another fragment landed in the glass. The inventory and laboratory comparison exposed that connection. He could take my fellowship and turn my unchecked reference against Art. I chose murder instead of publishing the correction.

Every selected suspect gets their final word.